xbnh-gpu

XBeach non-hydrostatic on the GPU: installation, use and validation

Stefano Biondi

Version 1.2, October 2026

Abstract

xbnh-gpu is a CUDA implementation of the one-layer non-hydrostatic (phase-resolving) flow solver of XBeach (trunk revision 6167). It reads XBeach input decks unchanged and writes XBeach-format output. Against Fortran XBeach it reproduces the significant wave height within 0.2 % and the mean current within 0.6 to 0.8 % when compared with serial XBeach. With cyclic lateral boundaries it is as close to XBeach MPI as XBeach MPI is to itself at a different number of ranks. On a full Estero Island storm deck (8.7 million cells), one RTX 2000 Ada GPU ran 4.1 times (double precision) and 9.5 times (single precision) faster than XBeach on 13 CPU cores. This guide explains how to install the code without administrator rights, build it for any recent NVIDIA GPU, run existing XBeach decks, and verify the results against a reference XBeach build that the repository also sets up.

Contents

1 What the code does **2**

2 Requirements **2**

3 Installation **3**
3.1 Automatic . . . 3
3.2 Manual . . . 3

4 Running a model **3**
4.1 Chaining segments . . . 4
4.2 Output . . . 4
4.3 Single or double precision . . . 4
4.4 GPU-specific keys . . . 5
4.5 Supported XBeach options . . . 5

5 Reference XBeach and tests **5**

6 Validation **6**
6.1 Rip-channel beach . . . 6
6.2 Estero-feature deck . . . 6
6.3 Estero Island storm deck . . . 7

7 Performance **8**

8 Numerical notes **9**

9 Troubleshooting **9**

10 License and citation **10**

1 What the code does

XBeach in non-hydrostatic mode (`wavemodel = nonh`) resolves individual waves with a depth-averaged momentum equation plus a vertical momentum equation and a non-hydrostatic pressure. The pressure is found from a Poisson equation at every time step. These equations are local stencil operations on a structured grid, which suit GPUs well: the cost is set by memory bandwidth, and a GPU has several times the bandwidth of a CPU socket.

xbnh-gpu follows the XBeach Fortran source routine by routine, each routine becoming one or more CUDA kernels:

- wet and dry cells and the time step (`wetcells.F90`, `timestep.F90`);
- boundary conditions, tide and wind (`boundaryconditions.F90`, `compute_tide_zs0.F90`, `readwind.F90`);
- momentum, viscosity and friction (`flow_timestep.F90`, `bedroughness.F90`);
- the non-hydrostatic predictor, breaking and pressure correction (`nonh.F90`);
- second-order advection (`flow_secondorder.F90`).

Where the Fortran depends on its sequential loop order, the GPU code reproduces the same result. This covers the neighbour checks of the breaking switch and two loop variables that XBeach reuses from earlier loops when it sets the vertical velocity at points outside the pressure solve.

There are two intentional differences.

1. **Pressure solver.** XBeach uses SIP, an incomplete-LU sweep that is sequential by construction. xbnh-gpu solves the same five-diagonal system with Jacobi-preconditioned BiCGStab to a relative residual of 10^{-3} (key `gpu_solver_acc`). Agreement with XBeach stops improving below this tolerance.
2. **Cyclic laterals.** XBeach supports `cyclic = 1` only under MPI, where the halo rows 1–2 and n_y–$n_y + 1$ are copied from the opposite side of the domain (period $n_y - 3$ rows). xbnh-gpu keeps the whole domain in one block, makes the same halo copies after every update of a prognostic field, and solves the pressure equation with periodic coupling. XBeach MPI does not exchange the velocities between the pressure correction and the continuity equation (section 8); xbnh-gpu does.

2 Requirements

- An NVIDIA GPU with compute capability 6.0 or newer: Pascal (P100, GTX 10xx) and later, including V100, T4, RTX 20xx/30xx/40xx, RTX Ada, A100 and H100. Check yours with `nvidia-smi --query-gpu=name,compute_cap --format=csv`.
- The NVIDIA driver, version 525.60 or newer (CUDA 12). On Windows, use WSL2 with the normal Windows NVIDIA driver; nothing GPU-related is installed inside WSL.
- Linux x86-64, or Windows 10/11 with WSL2 (Ubuntu). Installing WSL itself may need administrator rights once; everything after that runs in user space.
- About 3 GB of disk for the build environment, and 2 GB more for the optional reference XBeach.
- GPU memory: about 0.8 kB per grid cell in double precision and about half of that in single precision. An 8.7-million-cell grid used 6.8 GB in double precision.

No administrator rights are needed. The CUDA compiler, a compatible host C++ compiler, Python, and for the reference model gfortran and Open MPI, all come from conda-forge through micromamba. They are installed in the user's home directory.

3 Installation

3.1 Automatic

```
git clone <repository URL> xbnh-gpu
cd xbnh-gpu
./install.sh                    # GPU code only
./install.sh --with-xbeach      # GPU code and the reference Fortran XBeach (10-20
    min more)
source env.sh                   # in every new shell
bash tests/run_tests.sh
```

`install.sh` does the following.

1. It checks that `nvidia-smi` works and prints the GPU, its compute capability and the driver.
2. It installs micromamba in `~/.local/bin` if it is not already on the PATH. Environments go to `$MAMBA_ROOT_PREFIX`, which defaults to `~/micromamba`.
3. It creates the environment `xbnh-gpu` from `environment.yml`: CUDA 12.6 `nvcc`, GCC 13, make, Python 3.11 with NumPy, pandas and Matplotlib.
4. It builds `bin/xbnh_gpu` (double precision) and `bin/xbnh_gpu_sp` (single precision) for the GPU in the machine (`ARCH=native`).
5. With `--with-xbeach`, it also creates `xbnh-xbeach` (gfortran 13, Open MPI, autotools, Subversion) and runs `xbeach/build_xbeach.sh` (section 5).
6. It writes `env.sh`, which activates the environment, puts `bin/` on the PATH, and sets `XBEACH_SERIAL` and `XBEACH_MPI` to the reference executables.

3.2 Manual

With a CUDA toolkit (12.x) already available, for example on a cluster:

```
module load cuda                # on HPC systems; any CUDA >= 11.8 with a C++20
    host compiler
make ARCH=sm_80                 # cross-compile, e.g. on a login node without a
    GPU
```

ARCH	GPUs
native	the GPU in this machine (default)
sm_60	P100, GTX 10xx
sm_70	V100
sm_75	T4, RTX 20xx
sm_80	A100
sm_86	RTX 30xx, A40, A10
sm_89	RTX 40xx, RTX Ada, L4, L40
sm_90	H100

4 Running a model

xbnh-gpu runs in the folder that holds `params.txt`, like XBeach:

```
cd my_deck
xbnh_gpu          # double precision
xbnh_gpu_sp       # single precision
```

Use a separate folder from any XBeach run of the same deck. The output files have XBeach names and are overwritten. Linking the large input files avoids copies:

```
mkdir run_gpu && cd run_gpu && cp ../xbeach_run/params.txt .
for f in z.grd nhbcflist.bcf nh_series00001.bcf water_elev.dat wind.txt hotstart_
    *; do
  ln -s ../xbeach_run/$f .; done
xbnh_gpu > stdout.txt
```

4.1 Chaining segments

Long storms are usually run as a chain of shorter segments, each started from the state at the end of the previous one. With `writehotstart = 1` the GPU code writes the nine files that `hotstart = 1` reads (`hotstart_zs, zb, uu, vv, wb, ws, breaking, umean, vmean` plus a six-digit number) every `tinth` seconds, numbered from 1, in the same ASCII format as XBeach, so the files are interchangeable between the two codes. A 900 s segment written at its end is restarted with:

```
mkdir seg2 && cd seg2
cp ../seg1/hotstart_*000001.dat .        # copy, do not link: seg2 writes files
    of the same names
cp ../deck_seg2/params.txt ../deck_seg2/water_elev.dat ../deck_seg2/wind.txt .
python $XBNH/tools/set_params.py params.txt hotstart=1 hotstartfileno=1
    writehotstart=1 tinth=900 tstop=900
xbnh_gpu_sp > stdout.txt
```

Copy the hotstart files rather than linking them: a run that writes hotstart files of the same name would write through the links into the previous segment. Time restarts from zero in every segment, as in XBeach, so the tide, wind and boundary files of each segment start at its own $t = 0$.

Spectral wave boundaries. The GPU code reads a ready nonhydrostatic boundary series (`wbctype = reuse` or `ts_nonh`) but does not synthesise one from a spectrum. For a deck with `wbctype = swan`, `jonstable` or similar, run the reference XBeach on it once with a short `tstop` (a few seconds). XBeach writes `nhbcflist.bcf` and `nh_series00001.bcf` for the whole boundary duration before it starts stepping. Then set `wbctype = reuse` for the GPU run. Only the offshore boundary matters for this step, so a copy of the deck cut to `nx = 4` with the same `ny`, `dy` and spectra gives the same series much faster. The synthesis runs on one core; on the Estero deck (5740 boundary rows, 900 s) it takes one to two hours.

4.2 Output

- Global output for each variable listed under `nglobalvar` (`zs, u, v, uu, vv, ws, wb, hh, pres, breaking, zb, nuh, zs0`): one file `<var>.dat`, one float64 record of $(n_x + 1)(n_y + 1)$ values per `tintg`, with i (cross-shore) varying fastest. This is the XBeach `outputformat = fortran` layout. Read it in Python with `np.fromfile('zs.dat','<f8').reshape(-1, ny+1, nx+1)`.
- Point output for each point under `npoints`: `<name>.dat`, one record per `tintp` of `[t, var1, var2, ...]` in float64. Points snap to the nearest cell centre, as in XBeach.
- `xbgpu_log.txt`: precision, number of steps, wall time, solver time and iterations, and cost per cell and step. Progress goes to standard output every 2000 steps.

4.3 Single or double precision

Single precision is about 2.3 times faster and uses about half the memory. In every test so far it gave the same statistics as double precision. On the Estero deck it differed from double precision by 0.5 % in H_s and 0.001 m/s in mean current. Consumer GPUs are much slower in double precision than in single; data-centre GPUs (A100, H100) are not.

4.4 GPU-specific keys

Key	Default	Meaning
`gpu_solver_acc`	0.001	relative residual of the BiCGStab pressure solve
`gpu_maxit`	200	maximum BiCGStab iterations per step (about 13 are typical)
`gpu_hotstart_keepuv`	1	keep `uu, vv` from the hotstart files. Trunk XBeach zeroes them after reading; 0 reproduces that. The reference build here keeps them (section 5).

XBeach ignores these keys, apart from a warning about unknown parameters.

4.5 Supported XBeach options

Group	Supported
Model	`wavemodel = nonh`, `nonhq3d = 0`, `nhbreaker = 1`, `secorder = 1`, Smagorinsky (`smag`), Manning (`bedfriction = manning`), uniform `bedfriccoef` or per-cell `bedfricfile` (same layout as the depth file), `maxcf`, `mincf`
Grid	uniform rectilinear, `vardx = 0`, `alfa = 0`, $n_y > 4$
Offshore	`front = nonh_1d`, `ARC = 1`; `wbctype = ts_nonh` (`boun_U.bcf`) or `reuse` (`nhbcflist.bcf`, one entry, scalar or vector file with U, V, Z)
Back	`back = wall`, `abs_1d`, `abs_2d`
Laterals	`left`, `right` = `neumann` or `wall`; or `cyclic = 1`
Water level	`zs0`, or `zs0file` with `tideloc = 1`; `tidetype = velocity`
Wind	`windv`, `windth`, or `windfile`
Restart	read: `hotstart = 1`, `hotstartfileno`; write: `writehotstart = 1` every `tinth` (XBeach ASCII format, files numbered from 1)
Output	`nglobalvar`, `npoints`, `tintg`, `tintp` (fortran format)

Not supported: two-layer `nonhq3d`, variable or rotated grids, sediment and morphology, `tideloc` 2 or 4, several `nhbcflist` entries, netCDF output, and more than one GPU. Unsupported options stop the program with a message instead of being ignored.

5 Reference XBeach and tests

`xbeach/build_xbeach.sh` downloads XBeach trunk r6167 from the Deltares Subversion server (anonymous access) and applies two small patches (`xbeach/patch_xbeach.py`). It then builds `xbeach/dist_serial/bin/xbeach` and `xbeach/dist_mpi/bin/xbeach` (Open MPI), with Fortran output only. The two patches are:

1. **Hotstart velocities** (`initialize.F90`). Trunk reads `uu, vv` from the hotstart files and then sets them to zero in `flow_init`, so every restart starts from rest. The patch keeps them. The Estero runs used this build.
2. **Point output** (`postprocess.F90`). A missing comma in a log-message format makes runs with output points stop at start-up with "Missing comma between descriptors". This happens always in the serial build and intermittently under MPI. Only the message format changes.

`cyclic = 1` needs the MPI build with at least two ranks: `mpirun -np 4 $XBEACH_MPI`.

`tests/run_tests.sh` runs two small decks on the GPU in both precisions:

- a rip-channel beach (39 k cells, 120 s);
- the Estero-feature deck (40 k cells, 100 s; cyclic laterals, `abs_2d`, vector boundary, tide and wind files, point output);
- a hotstart round trip on the Estero-feature deck: a 40 s run writes a hotstart, a second run restarts from it, and the restarted water level and velocities must match to 10^{-6};

- a per-cell Manning map: a uniform `bedfricfile` of 0.02 must reproduce `bedfriccoef = 0.02` to round-off (10^{-9}).

When the reference XBeach exists, the same decks run in Fortran XBeach and the agreement is checked against thresholds. Otherwise the GPU statistics are checked against values stored in `tests/reference.json`. The thresholds are several times the differences that XBeach itself shows between rank counts. The tests take two to five minutes. A passing run with the reference XBeach ends like this (the numbers are from the RTX 2000 Ada):

```
 Fortran XBeach (serial) against GPU
   Hs_rel          0.0014  (limit 0.01)  ok
   current_rel     0.0045  (limit 0.03)  ok
   zs_rms_m        0.0027  (limit 0.01)  ok
 ...
 Fortran XBeach (MPI, 2 ranks) against GPU
   Hs_rel          0.0032  (limit 0.02)  ok
   current_rel     0.0046  (limit 0.1)  ok
   zs_rms_m        0.0029  (limit 0.02)  ok
== 3. hotstart write and restart (Estero-feature deck)
 ...
   zs  max difference after restart 5.0e-09  (limit 1e-06)  ok
   uu  max difference after restart 5.0e-09  (limit 1e-06)  ok
   vv  max difference after restart 5.0e-09  (limit 1e-06)  ok
   PASS
== 4. Manning map (bedfricfile): a uniform map must reproduce bedfriccoef
 ...
   zs  max difference 9.6e-13  (limit 1e-09, round-off)  ok
   PASS
tests passed: 12, failed: 0
```

6 Validation

6.1 Rip-channel beach

The deck has 39 k cells and dx = 2 m (`examples/rip_beach`):

- a 1:50 slope with a shore-parallel bar cut by rip channels;
- JONSWAP waves (H_{m0} = 1 m, T_p = 8 s) driven through `boun_U.bcf`, for 200 s.

Statistics are for $t \geq 60$ s (Table 1, Figure 1).

Table 1: Rip-channel beach: differences against serial Fortran XBeach.

Metric	GPU fp64	GPU fp32	XBeach MPI-4
H_s map, relative RMSE	0.16 %	0.18 %	0.36 %
Mean current, relative RMSE	0.62 %	0.61 %	1.59 %
Set-up RMSE	0.21 mm	0.21 mm	0.43 mm
Instantaneous z_s, RMS difference	3.5 mm	3.6 mm	4.1 mm

6.2 Estero-feature deck

`examples/estero_features` combines every option of the Estero Island deck on 40 k cells:

- cyclic laterals;
- a wet `abs_2d` back boundary;
- a short-crested sea, 20° oblique, given as a vector U, V, Z file;

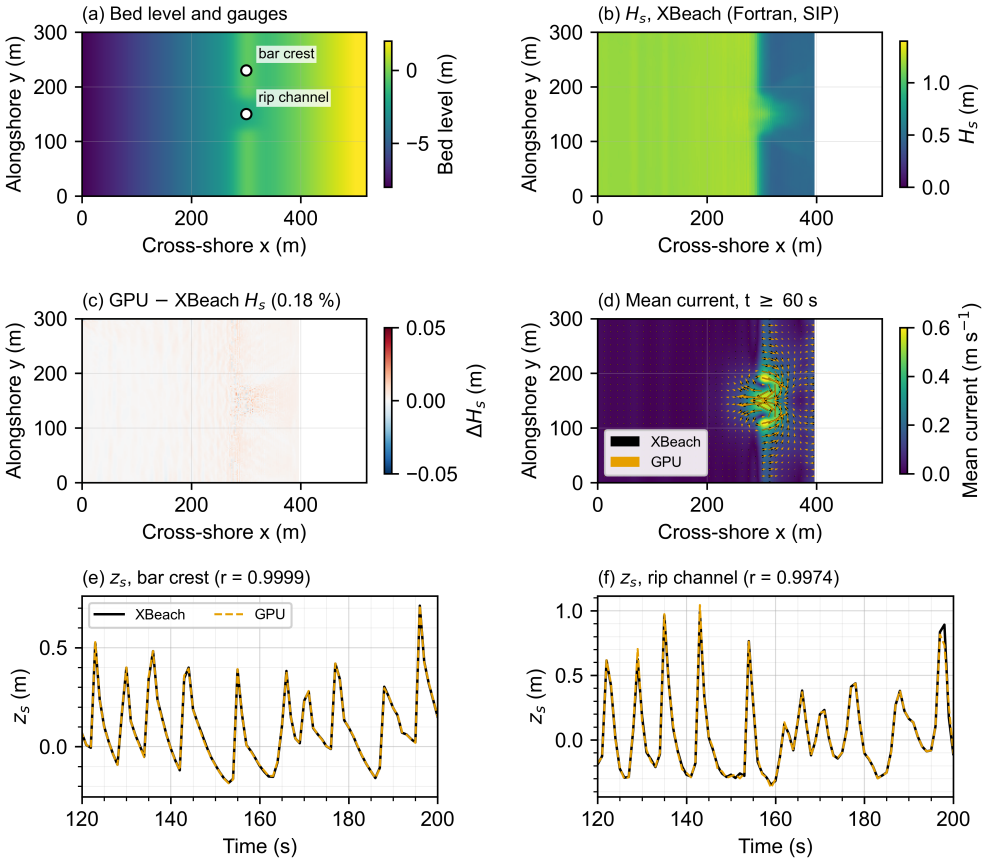


Figure 1: Rip-channel beach. (a) Bed and gauges; (b) XBeach H_s; (c) GPU minus XBeach H_s; (d) mean currents of both codes; (e, f) water level at the bar crest and in the rip channel.

- a rising tide from `zs0file` and a time-varying wind;
- point output, and a hotstart written at 100 s.

Table 2 lists the results.

Table 2: Estero-feature deck (relative RMSE of maps; z_s as RMS difference).

Comparison	H_s	Mean current	Longshore current	z_s
Serial XBeach vs GPU, hotstart, Neumann laterals	0.20 %	0.82 %	1.2 %	2.6 mm
XBeach MPI-2 vs GPU, cyclic	0.34 %	2.0 %	2.3 %	4.7 mm
XBeach MPI-4 vs GPU, cyclic	0.54 %	3.4 %	4.9 %	6.2 mm
XBeach MPI-4 vs MPI-2 (yardstick)	0.44 %	2.8 %	2.9 %	5.5 mm

6.3 Estero Island storm deck

The full Estero Island deck (Hurricane Ian, 1515 × 5739 cells at 2 m) was run for 300 s from a hotstart, with the same input files as XBeach on 13 MPI ranks. At the 50 output points the median differences against XBeach were as follows:

- H_s: 1.9 %;
- mean current: 0.002 m/s, of a median 1.04 m/s;
- maximum speed: 0.8 %.

For scale, the same CPU run with only the wind drag changed differed by 3.4 %, 0.19 m/s and 7.9 % (Figure 2). Wave phases at individual points begin to separate after about 230 s, as they do between any two XBeach runs with different rank counts.

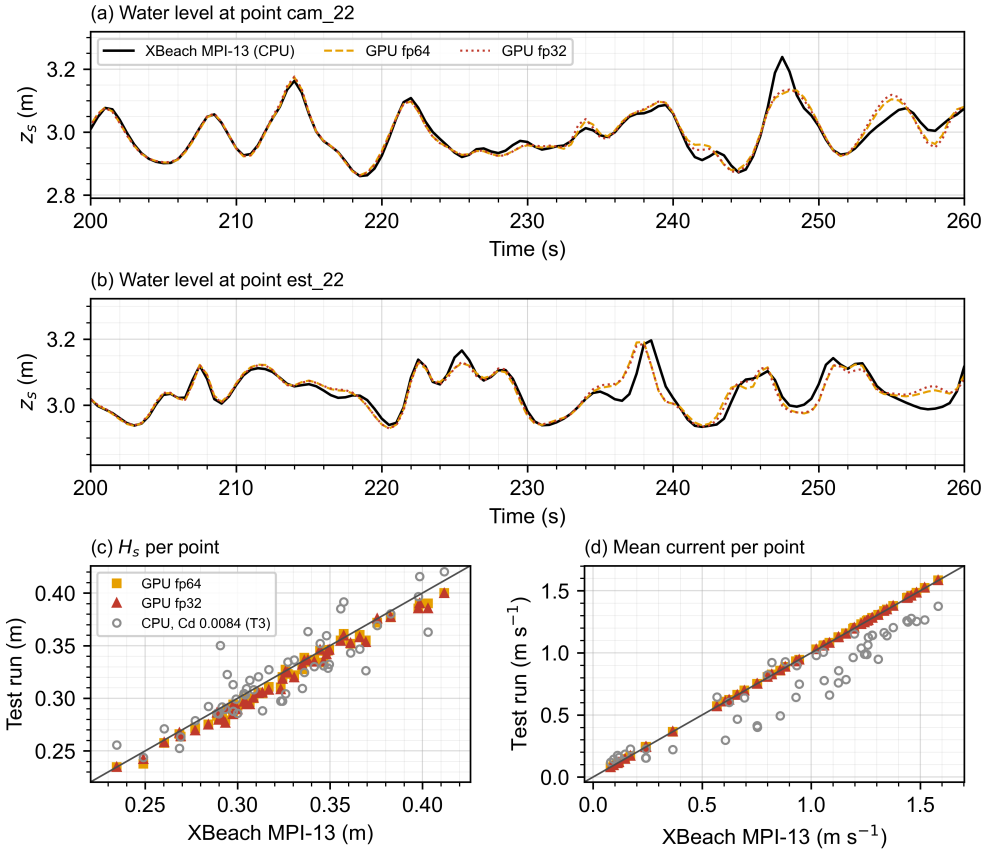


Figure 2: Estero Island deck. (a, b) Water level at two output points; (c) H_s and (d) mean current at the 50 points: GPU against XBeach MPI-13, with a CPU wind-drag sensitivity run for scale.

7 Performance

Table 3 lists the wall time per cell and time step on an RTX 2000 Ada (16 GB) and an i9-14900K (8 performance and 16 efficiency cores). The deck is the rip-channel beach, stretched alongshore. Figure 3 shows the same benchmark.

Table 3: Cost per cell and time step (s).

Cells	XBeach MPI, best rank count	GPU fp64	GPU fp32	Speed-up fp64 / fp32
0.16 M	8.8e-8 (24 ranks)	4.6e-8	2.1e-8	1.9 / 4.2
0.63 M	1.0e-7 (32 ranks)	4.6e-8	1.9e-8	2.2 / 5.5
2.5 M	1.35e-7 (32 ranks)	4.4e-8	1.9e-8	3.1 / 7.1
8.7 M	1.39e-7 (24 ranks)	4.3e-8	1.8e-8	3.2 / 7.7

The scaling has three features worth knowing.

- The CPU stops gaining beyond about 8 ranks, because all cores share the same memory bandwidth.
- The GPU cost per cell is flat from 0.16 to 8.7 million cells.
- The pressure solve takes about half of the GPU time.

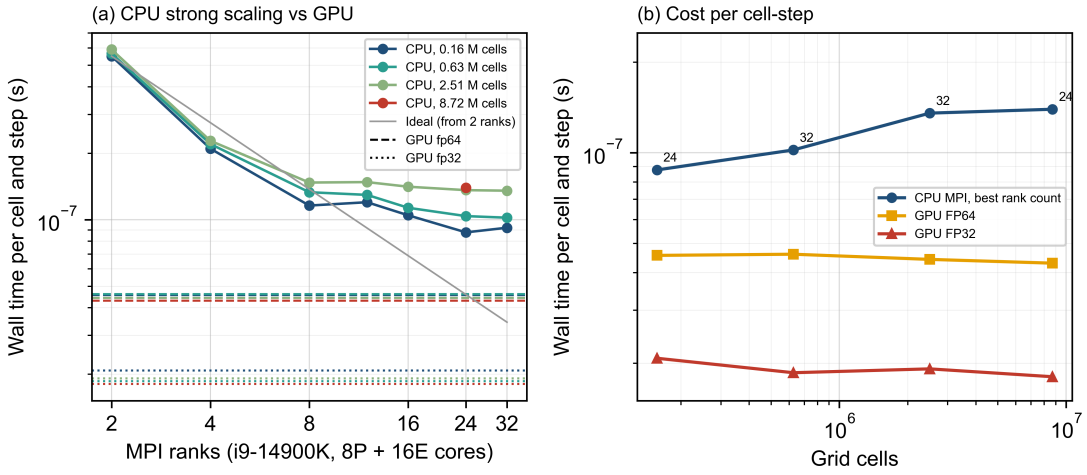


Figure 3: (a) XBeach MPI strong scaling on one workstation (lines) against the GPU (horizontal: dashed fp64, dotted fp32); (b) cost per cell and step against grid size.

On the Estero Island deck the 300 s time loop took 121 min with XBeach on 13 ranks, against 29.3 min (fp64) and 12.8 min (fp32) on the GPU. A data-centre GPU (A100, H100) is expected to be another 8 to 15 times faster in double precision, but this has not been measured yet.

To reproduce the benchmark:

```
SIZES="600 2400 9600" RANKS="2 4 8 16" bash tools/benchmark.sh bench
python tools/plot_benchmark.py bench/benchmark.csv
```

8 Numerical notes

- **Results do not depend on the decomposition.** The GPU domain is a single block, so results do not change with core count. XBeach MPI results do: between 2 and 4 ranks, mean currents differ by about 3 % in the tests above.
- **One cause of the XBeach drift.** XBeach MPI exchanges `uu, vv` after the momentum equation, the predictor and the second-order advection. It does not exchange them after the pressure correction, so at each subdomain seam the continuity equation uses an uncorrected halo velocity. The Estero hotstart files show this: their halo rows of `vv` differ from the rows they copy by up to 4.6 cm/s, while `zs` matches exactly.
- **Run-to-run reproducibility.** Two runs of xbnh-gpu on the same GPU agree to about 10^{-14} m, not bit for bit, because the dot products of the solver are summed with atomic operations.
- **Unstable corner with Neumann laterals.** With Neumann laterals and an oblique vector boundary, the corner where the offshore and lateral boundaries meet can become unstable in both codes. After that, the runs separate. Use cyclic laterals for oblique seas.

9 Troubleshooting

`nvidia-smi` not found, or "CUDA driver version is insufficient"
Install or update the NVIDIA driver (525.60 or newer). On WSL2, update the Windows driver; do not install a Linux driver inside WSL.

`nvcc fatal: Unsupported gpu architecture 'compute_native'`
No GPU is visible during the build (for example on a login node). Build with `make ARCH=sm_XY` from the table in section 3.

"CUDA error out of memory"
The grid is too large for the card. Use `xbnh_gpu_sp` (about half the memory) or a larger GPU.

"xbnh_gpu: ... not supported"
The deck uses an option outside the supported list; the message names it.

"time step collapsed"
The solution became unstable and the time step went to zero; XBeach stops in the same way. Check the deck in XBeach first.

`micromamba create` fails or hangs (blocked conda-forge)
Some institutional networks block or inspect traffic to conda-forge. Set the proxy first (`export https_proxy=http://proxy:port`), or skip micromamba if a CUDA toolkit (12.x, with `g++` 10 or newer) is already installed: `make NVCC=/usr/local/cuda/bin/nvcc`, then run the tests with any Python that has NumPy. `env.sh` is then not needed; put `bin/` on `PATH` and set `XBNH` to the repository folder.

No MPI reference XBeach ("no XBeach MPI build found")
The tests then compare the Estero-feature deck with stored XBeach statistics instead, which is enough to validate the GPU build. The MPI build needs Open MPI from `environment-xbeach.yml`.

XBeach stops with "Missing comma between descriptors"
This is an unpatched XBeach with output points. Use the build from `xbeach/build_xbeach.sh`.

10 License and citation

XBeach is developed by Deltares, UNESCO-IHE and Delft University of Technology and distributed under the GNU Lesser General Public License. xbnh-gpu translates XBeach routines to CUDA and is distributed under the same license (LGPL-3.0). Please cite the XBeach model [1] and its non-hydrostatic breaking formulation [2] when using xbnh-gpu.

References

[1] Roelvink, D., Reniers, A., van Dongeren, A., van Thiel de Vries, J., McCall, R., Lescinski, J. (2009). Modelling storm impacts on beaches, dunes and barrier islands. *Coastal Engineering*, 56(11–12), 1133–1152. doi:10.1016/j.coastaleng.2009.08.006

[2] Smit, P., Zijlema, M., Stelling, G. (2013). Depth-induced wave breaking in a non-hydrostatic, near-shore wave model. *Coastal Engineering*, 76, 1–16. doi:10.1016/j.coastaleng.2013.01.008